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Assignment #1: Lessons Learned

For Senior Design I, there were many great learning opportunities and chances to grow. Some of these lessons were just in organizing the project with certain applications such as GitHub, latex, and Agile. However, the greater lessons learned concerned project management. Namely, how to have effective engaging team meetings with great time management, how to delegate and distribute work effectively to each team member, especially with maximum strengths and minimizing the threat of weaknesses, and lastly, being disciplined in the simple rule of working hard and working early. Understanding the significance of these lessons and how to employ them is something I'm still learning, such as with effective team meetings.

I think it's very easy to see that slow, sludgy team meetings can be the worst and really be a mental drain instead of good prep and advice to get more work done collectively. I learned a good part of this when we had our first meeting with our sponsor and subsequent meetings with each other weekly. Usually, we had to decide the day before if we would even need a meeting or what we would meet for. Therefore, what I found was effective for team meetings was making sure of a meeting topic beforehand and being gently specific on what needed to discuss as it pertained to us technically. For example, we may need to have a meeting on what to do for our next sprint plan, this was the topic, but the specifics to be discussed may be something we texted amongst each other such as about the planning for future sprints and what might or might not be good. We then had topics for points of discussion over our main topic at hand. But what followed these meetings was just dedication.

Once, we did have these meetings one lesson I learned which in hindsight is important but is hard to deny yourself to do is just working hard and working on things early. I found myself constantly behind on things and it showed how that affected my teammates when meetings go on longer than they need just because we slacked, or I slacked on things that just should have been done pre-meeting. A nice bit I had come to learn is bit is from biblical scripture that "laziness is brother to he that destroys". Even if I was lazy at working on things for a long time, not doing the work early just turned out to be a deadly combo and a detriment to the team, not just myself. With early planning and hard work willing that allowed me to do the things others didn't want to do we were able to get much down as a team.

Lastly, effective meetings and planning also allowed our overall performance to be better. It's good that the work in Senior Design was easy in the beginning because as we figured out the intricate details of our project, we needed to effectively distribute workloads based on everyone's schedule and knowledge or skill. For all of us, we had to learn, but we also had to understand who could learn it the fastest and who would have the time to offload what needed to be done. Just having the opportunity to work together on various documents and presentations helped us to see each other's capabilities and general weaknesses and cover for each other. As an example, one of us may be more inclined to slack, so it's good that they work with another person for accountability and do work together, but that person also has a task that requires another teammate. For another, it's good that they do independent work that complements the team and if very knowledgeable can work on critical tasks with confidence.

These are just some of the things I had the opportunity to learn in Senior Design I, and I hope we can be even more effective in these areas now in Senior Design II. As we continue on, just like with Senior Design I we will learn how to be more flexible, to be disciplined and how to maximize our efforts overall.